Rewriting a Confusing Setup Guide

Technical Writing | Software Documentation

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The Original

To integrate the widget into your website, it is necessary to first obtain an API key from the developer dashboard, which may be accessed by authenticating with your account credentials and navigating to the relevant settings panel, following which the key should be inserted into the initialisation snippet and the snippet subsequently embedded within the HTML of the page on which the widget is to be rendered, ensuring that the script is placed prior to the closing body tag. It should be noted that cross-origin resource sharing (CORS) must be appropriately configured on the server, failing which requests may be rejected, and that the widget will not render if the domain has not been whitelisted within the dashboard. Should the widget fail to appear, verify that the API key is valid, that the domain is correctly whitelisted, and that no content security policy (CSP) directives are preventing the script from executing.

The Diagnostic

This is a setup guide that assumes the reader already knows how to complete it. Everything needed to succeed is present, but it is buried in prose, out of order, and written for someone who does not need the guide in the first place. The specific problems:

1. **No prerequisites up front.** The reader only discovers what they need (an account, a page whose HTML they can edit, server access for CORS) scattered through the paragraph, after they have already started. A setup guide should open with what to have ready, so no one gets halfway and hits a wall.

2. **It is one unbroken sentence, not steps.** A procedure has to be numbered so the reader can see how many steps there are, track where they are, and stop and come back without losing their place. Prose forces them to hold the whole process in their head at once.

3. **Passive voice hides who acts.** "The key should be inserted," "the snippet subsequently embedded" never say plainly that the reader does these things. In instructions, every step should start with a verb the reader performs, so there is no doubt about who does what.

4. **Undefined jargon.** API key, CORS, CSP, whitelisting, and "closing body tag" are used with no explanation and no link. The reader who needs this guide is often exactly the reader who does not know those terms, so each one is a point where they silently give up.

5. **Failure conditions are buried, not flagged.** The two things most likely to break the setup, an un-whitelisted domain and CORS, are mentioned in passing, in the middle of the text. They should be called

out at the step where they matter, so the reader prevents the problem instead of discovering it after the widget fails.

6. **The snippet is referenced but never shown.** "The initialisation snippet" is central to the whole task, yet it does not appear anywhere. The reader cannot copy what they cannot see.

7. **Troubleshooting is a run-on list.** The three failure checks are strung together in one clause. Troubleshooting works best as a map from symptom to fix, so a stuck reader can find their exact problem and jump straight to the answer.

The Rewrite

Add the [App] widget to your website

This takes about 10 minutes. Before you start, make sure you have:

- An [App] account.
- Access to edit your website's HTML, or the custom-code / embed section of your site builder (Wix, Squarespace, Shopify, and similar).

1. **Get your API key.** Sign in to [App], go to Settings, then Developer, and copy your API key. Think of the API key as a private password that lets your website talk to [App].

2. **Copy the embed snippet.** On the same page, copy the snippet below. You will replace YOUR_API_KEY with the key you just copied.

```
<script src="https://cdn.[app].com/widget.js"
        data-key="YOUR_API_KEY"></script>
```

3. **Add the snippet to your page.** Paste it just before the </body> tag on the page where you want the widget to appear. If you use a site builder, paste it into the custom-code or embed section instead.

4. **Allow your domain.** Back in Settings, then Developer, add your website's address (for example, yoursite.com) to the Allowed Domains list. The widget will not load on any domain that is not on this list, so do not skip this step.

5. **Save and refresh.** Reload your page. The widget should appear within a few seconds.

If something goes wrong

Problem	Fix
The widget does not appear	Check that your domain is on the Allowed Domains list and spelled exactly, with no https:// and no trailing slash.
You see an "invalid key" error	Copy the API key again and make sure there are no extra spaces

	before or after it.
It works on your computer but not on the live site	Your site's content security policy may be blocking the script. Add cdn.[app].com to your policy, or ask your developer to.
Still stuck	Contact us at [support link] with the page address, and we will take a look.

Bracketed fields ([App], [support link]) are placeholders, since they change per product. The snippet is illustrative and would carry each product's real script URL.